We can derive Poiseuille's equation using dimensional analysis. Consider a liquid flowing steadily through a horizontal capillary tube. Let $\upsilon = \left(\frac{V}{t}\right)$ be the volume of the liquid flowing out per second through a capillary tube. It depends on (1) coefficient of viscosity (η) of the liquid, (2) radius of the tube (r), and (3) the pressure gradient $\left(\frac{P}{l}\right)$. Then,

$$\upsilon \propto \eta^a r^b \left(\frac{P}{l}\right)^c$$

$$\upsilon = k\eta^a r^b \left(\frac{P}{l}\right)^c \qquad (7.24)$$

where, k is a dimensionless constant. Therefore,

$$[\upsilon] = \frac{\text{volume}}{\text{time}} = \left[L^3T^{-1}\right], \left[\frac{dP}{dx}\right] = \frac{\text{Pressure}}{\text{distance}}$$

$$\left[ML^{-2}T^{-2}\right], [\eta] = \left[ML^{-1}T^{-1}\right] and [r] = [L]$$

Substituting in equation (7.24)

$$\left[L^3T^{-1}\right] = \left[ML^{-1}T^{-1}\right]^a [L]^b \left[ML^{-2}T^{-2}\right]^c$$

$$M^0L^3T^{-1} = M^{a+c}L^{-a+b-2c}T^{-a-2c}$$

So, equating the powers of M, L, and T on both sides, we get

$$a + c = 0, -a + b - 2c = 3, \text{ and } -a - 2c = -1$$

We have three unknowns a, b, and c. We have three equations, on solving, we get

$$a = -1, b = 4, \text{ and } c = 1$$

Therefore, equation (7.24) becomes,

$$\upsilon = k\eta^{-1}r^4 \left(\frac{P}{l}\right)^1$$

Experimentally, the value of k is shown to be $\frac{\pi}{8}$, we have

$$\upsilon = \frac{\pi r^4 P}{8\eta l} \qquad (7.25)$$

The above equation is known as *Poiseuille's equation* for the flow of liquid through a narrow tube or a capillary tube. This relation holds good for the fluids whose velocities are lesser than the critical velocity (v_c).

7.4.8 Applications of viscosity

The importance of viscosity can be understood from the following examples.

(1) The oil used as a lubricant for heavy machinery parts should have a high viscous coefficient. To select a suitable lubricant, we should know its viscosity and how it varies with temperature [Note: As temperature increases, the viscosity of the liquid decreases]. Also, it helps to choose oils with low viscosity used in car engines (light machinery).

(2) The highly viscous liquid is used to damp the motion of some instruments and is used as brake oil in hydraulic brakes.

(3) Blood circulation through arteries and veins depends upon the viscosity of fluids.

(4) Millikan conducted the oil drop experiment to determine the charge of an electron. He used the knowledge of viscosity to determine the charge.

7.5 SURFACE TENSION

7.5.1 Intermolecular forces

Some liquids do not mix together due to their physical properties such as density, surface tension force, etc. For example, water and kerosene do not mix together. Mercury does not wet the glass but water sticks to it. Water

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